

BRIEF HISTORY OF THE ADVENT OF CHRISTIANITY AMONG THE SIMTES

(1917-1958)

The gospel spread firstly in the Northern District of Manipur by William Pettigrew in around 1891. While the gospel in the southern part was spread initially by Watkin R. Roberts in Senvon on 10th May, 1910. Watkin Roberts was a Presbyterian minister in Wales who dedicated his life for Jesus Christ after hearing sermon from Reuben R. Torry. Torry's message challenged Watkin R. Roberts to go to the heathen land such as India. Taking a firm decision to reach the unreached, Roberts came along with Dr. Peter Fraser and his wife reaching Aizawl on 14th October 1908. ⁱIn Aizawl, they all worked in hospital. Dr. Peter Fraser and his wife took care of the patients, while Roberts was confined to distributing medicines. In 1909 Emily Davis from England sent 15 pounds to Watkin Roberts. Roberts spend the money wisely by printing 104 copies of gospel tracts which includes John 3:16 "for God so loved the world that he gave his only begotten son, that whosoever believe in Him shall not perish but have everlasting life". He began to send the gospel tracts to the chief of Senvon in Manipur. ⁱⁱ

In reply to Robert's gospel tract, Kamkholun Singson writes a letter which was carried by three youths travelling to Aizawl to take medicines for Robert. The letter writes "You yourself come down and explain the tract" Dr. Fraser and Roberts were so excited in seeing the letter and requested Major H.W.G. Cole, Political Agent Manipur, to grant him to visit the land (enter Manipur). The political agent did not grant his permission because of the recent assassination of 5 foreigners. Risking his life, Robert went to Senvon along with Thangkai and Lungpau along with Savawma, Vanzika and Thangchiingpuia on 10th May 1910. Soon after that, missions began to expand leading to the formation of Thadou-Kuki Pioneer Mission (TKPM) in 1914. In 1916 Robert's mission began to expand in Tripura and Chittagong Hill Tracts. Seeing the growth of believers in Manipur and Tripura, Robert changed the named TKPM to North East India General Mission (NEIGM) in 1919. ⁱⁱⁱ

Through the evangelistic work of TKPM and NEIGM missions, gospel reached each and every villages of Southern Manipur. Among the many tribes found in the Southern Manipur, villages of Simte tribes came to hear the gospel through the TKPM mission in 1917. ^{iv}

The Simtes are one of the tribes of the Kuki-Mizo-community in Manipur. They are mostly concentrated in the southern part of Manipur. Rev. Khamkhosiam Hangnung, former Executive Secretary, NTBCA states

The gospel was first heard among the Simte as early as 1917 but its propagation was rather slow. The new faith was not readily accepted by the Simte because they were faithful to their animist worship. Also, the Simte villages were highly organized with the chiefs at the top. The chiefs of the Simte villages did not welcome the new faith, which made the inroad of Christianity into the tribe became slow and rather very difficult. But, by the grace of God there was a change in the Simte society with the passage of time and there was a good progress in Christianity in the 1940s and a good number of the Simte People started embracing the new faith.^v

S. Lianzathang Ngaihte in his book “The Ngaihtes” discussed how the gospel had been rejected. He further added that in spite of the steep opposition the gospel expanded to the entire Simte villages. Some instance may be cited to narrate the scenario of how the gospel seed was shown to the Simte villages. In Thanlon, evangelist like Thangvang Guite, Lungpau, Thangkai and Pastor Vannchunga first preached the gospel among the Simte. They preached and went to other villages. During those times the Christian evangelist were mocked and excommunicated from their villages. Mr. Zagin, once an inhabitant of Thanlon narrated that gospel was preached by the evangelist with fear and hardship. Many people poured in to hear the gospel in secluded place in Thanlon village. Knowing this, chief Lumthang enquired the village crier whether Pastor Vannchunga came and preached the gospel. After confirmation from the village crier, the chief ordered some volunteers to cast the evangelist out of the village.^{vi}

There were also opposition of gospel from older people who were well rooted in their traditional beliefs and sacrificial practices. Added to this, the older people were fond of drinking wine, which was served as an entertainment and sacrifice to appease the evil spirit. Against all odds, younger people open their hearts to accept the new faith. Mr. Nengzagou orally narrated that he became Christian on June 9, 1935 and started worshipping inside *Phoh Buh*- a temporarily house built with thatched roofing. As the gospel seed began to bear fruit, NEIGM sent Pastor P.K. Englian to take care of the new believers from 1939-1943. Even after his transfer to Kaihlam village, he kept visiting Thanlon. Hence, P. K. Englian became a spiritual father for the people of Thanlon.

Soon the minority Christian community in Thanlon started spreading their faith to unbelievers leading to numerous growths. And these new believers began to evangelize their neighbouring Simte villages. Hence, some people in different villages came to accept Jesus as their personal saviour^{vii}.

In Sumtuh village, the gospel seed was first planted by Evangelist Thangvang. But due to failure in discipleship of Christian doctrine, it did not bear fruit. However, the fruitful harvest of Christian faith in Sumtuh was evidenced in 1936 through the commitment and work of Evangelist Tongpu Tungnung. Some of the Pioneer Christians were: Thangzaneng, Kailal, Chinkhopau, Gindailou, Tualzagin, B.Vumzagin etc. Notably, the early preaching were done in Lushai language. S. Ngulzathang recollects his past memories of the early Christian life in Sumtuh. He claimed that “I read the book of John 8:12 and came to know that, In the beginning was the word.... In him was life and the life was the light of men. I was convinced by these words and I became a Christian”. The growth of the Christians brings forth the establishment of church in 1939. Initially, they were affiliated to NEIGM, but later shift to NTBCA in the late 1950s.^{viii}

In Leizangphai village, gospel message was preached firstly by Ramlian Hmar, Lungpau Vaiphei and Thangkai Vaiphei in the year 1947. Surprising, there was no steep opposition in Leizangphai village. Mr. Zamnang, a pioneer Christian narrates that he read the Bible by himself and read John 3:16 “For God so loves the world that he gave his only begotten son that whosoever believe in him but have everlasting life”. Convinced of the love of God amidst his sinful personality, he came to accept Jesus as his saviour. The early Christians were: Zamnang, Paokhovung, Nengkhogin, Nengzalam, Khaizagin, Kamlam, H.Loukham etc. Under the leadership of Ngulzathang, a church was constructed in 1950. Initially, the church in Leizangphai were under the presbytery of NEIGM, but later affiliated to NTBCA in 1958.^{ix}

Concerning the coming of Christianity in Dumsau village, Pastor Khaizatong narrates the coming and growth of the church as follows:

The contemporary pioneer Christians of Dumsau villages were: Thongzakham, Thangkhotong, and chinzakhup. Evangelist Dengkung and Thomlian Leivang were the first to preach the gospel in Dumsau village. The fruit of their labour was the coming of the neophyte Christians like Hinchinpau, Kamkhomang, Semminthang, Heldong etc. , and among women were Chingzahat, Tongniang, etc. Having no church building for a petty long time, the early

Christians used to go to neighbouring Mualbem village for attending Sunday worship service among the Hmar people and also their children attended the children Sunday school there. It was around 1956, after shifting the Dumsau village from the top of Dumsau hill to the valley below, the church building construction was started with the initiative taken up by the young pioneer Christians. During that time Pastor P.K. Englian of the NEIGM with its headquarters at Tuikham village looked after Dumsau Christians. The Dumsau Christians joined SCA in 1951, which the church later on changed to NTBCA.^x

Pastor P. K. Englian was the pioneer in sowing the seed of the gospel in another Simte village known as “Khuangnung”. The first believer T. Chinzakhup constructed a thatched church in 1953. Interestingly, the Khuangnung church introduced an indigenous principle of church growth-self governing, self propagating and self-supporting until 1957. In 1958 with the affiliation of the church to NTBCA they pool their resources-finance, human etc to them^{xi}

Surprisingly, the NEIGM took initiatives to evangelize and nurture the spiritual needs of the Simte during the time when Simte Christian were few in number. L. Liankhanlal Simte in his thesis entitled “The Origin and growth of Christianity among the Simtes in Manipur” narrated the days the Simte were under the NEIGM mission:

In the early days of Christianity the Simte believers were under the care of evangelists from NEIGM for their spiritual growth. Literally there had been no workers from among the Simte community working under NEIGM. All the evangelists even after the whole community was converted were from other communities employed by NEIGM. Therefore, the Simtes belonged to NEIGM and depended on it for all religious matters. In 1948, NEIGM was divided into five presbyteries namely, Simkhang (South west) Presbytery, Simsak (South east) Presbytery, Malkhang (North east) Presbytery, Malsak (North East) Presbytery and Vangai Presbytery. The division fell on ethnic lines, tribe wise to be precise. Simsak Presbytery consisted of mostly the people who spoke Paite dialect and its language affinity groups. The Simtes belonged to Simsak Presbytery. The Simsak Presbytery was changed into Manipur Christian Convention in 1949, which was later changed into Evangelical Convention Church (ECC). The Simtes joined ECC until their separation from it to form an autonomous church^{xii}

During the early years of the advent of Christianity among the Simte villages, there had been no western missionaries. The native evangelist from Hmar and Paite community took initiative to preach the gospel to their neighbouring villages. Those evangelists were sent through NEIGM. They sacrificed their lives for the gospel. Subsequently, through the tireless

effort of the NEIGM in general and particularly the native evangelists, the whole community was evangelised.^{xiii}

According to Th.Kaikhochin, Deacon, NTBC, Bible Hill, part of Simte villages joined Convention Presbytery for Paite and Part of the Simte villages join Assembly Presbytery for Hmar. Later on, some of the Simte Christians joined the Indo-Burma Pioneer Mission (IBPM), a mission which was started by Watkin R. Roberts after he split the mission with H.H. Coleman in 1930. The leaders who joined IBPM sent a letter to the NEIGM leaders that they no longer relate/associate with them. This letter affects the delegates of the Simte community that they were not allowed to take part in the NEIGM General Assembly. From there on the relationship between the Simte Christians and NEIGM came to an end. He further states that though he could not recollect the exact year, but he was sure that it was way back in the late 1930s^{xiv} Under the IBPM, pioneer Christians such as B.Khupzakham, B. Nengzagou, Lamzakhai, H.Tualchin, H.Thongzakham and Th.Gindailou brainstorm together for the formation of a separate church association for the Simtes. A meeting was convened at Mongon village, Thanlon Sub-Division of Churachandpur District, Manipur on 22nd March 1951. They formed an association known as Simte Christian Association (SCA). L. Jeeyaselan recollect the formation of SCA as “Delegates from twelve villages numbering to almost three hundreds deliberated the ways and means for church growth. They felt the need of conducting crusades to preach the gospel to other people” The four Simte Christian Association’s standing committee members were: 1. Nengzagou appointed as Chairman 2. Khupzakham appointed as Secretary 3. Dongkhosoi appointed as Member 4. Jamkhai appointed as Member. 5. Gindailou appointed as Member^{xv}

After withdrawing its partnership with NEIGM missions, the SCA was supporting themselves in finance and in all affairs of administration. There was no parental or pastoral care in biblical truth. Discipleship and strong hermeneutical biblical teaching is lacking among the SCA. In such a situation, there has been a consciousness to affiliate with more biblical mission agency. Rev. Khamkhosiam Hangnung narrates

Keeping the need for affiliation with more biblical mission agency in mind, Henjamang Thangsing, a medical student at Berry White Medical School, Dibrugarh, was assigned to look for his mission agency. In 1947 August, he met Mr. K.A. Koireng Singh, a Manipuri Evangelist. The latter advised him to go and meet missionaries. Having heeded the wise advice, he immediately went to Cachar and he met Rev. James S. Garlow, Superintendent, Baptist Mid Missions, Assam. Rev. James S. Garlow warmly received the young Simte lad

and prayed with him. Both of them had a brief discussion and agreed in principle to work together in the Lord's vineyard.^{xvi}

Ts. Kaikhomang, in his biographical book of his father named "(L) Henzamang Thangsing Tanchinbu", asserted that his father was a patriotic man who always longed to do something for his Simte tribe. From 1949-1950 Henzamang Thangsing was working in Alipur Dispensary, Cachar District, Assam. During those days, Thangsing was looking for Christian partnership in Alipur, Assam who could nurture the spiritual growth of the Simte tribes. Following the search for partnership, Thangsing met Rev. Dr. James S. Garlow, who was working in Alipur Mission Hospital, Burrow Memorial Christian Hospital and Tuberculosis Sanatorium of Mid Mission, Cachar District, Assam on 08-06-1949. This hospital was under the ministry of Baptist Mid Mission (BMM)^{xvii}. Thangsing also told Dr. Garlow the desperate need for the Bible in Simte language. As asked by the government of Manipur to work in the state, Thangsing left Alipur. But both Thangsing and Dr. Garlow agreed to work together in principle. A constant contact with them went through letters. Beside letters, the church sent Th. Thuam Mang and Nengkhosuan to Alipur to meet Dr. Garlow. The agreement in principle became practical from 1954 by sending young men and women for Bible training and nurses training. Gradually, James S. Garlow visited Thanlon on October, 1957. He also visited Dumsau Village, there he baptized 50 new believers before he left Alipur^{xviii}. To authenticate BMM's partnership with the Simte Christians, Garlow came along with John E. Wilkens accompanied by their sons Douglas Garlow and Douglas Wilken. Thus, the agreement between SCA and BMM was finalised in 1958.^{xix} Hh. Khaizathang, Deacon, Bible Hill asserted that the agreement was made between SCA and BMM in principle and through mutual trust. And their partnership keeps on going till today. Surprisingly, no formal agreement letter was signed in 1958. But the absence of formal agreement letter must not be undermined.^{xx} In addition, S. Thangzagin and Th. Lianchin were appointed as evangelist that same year. Moreover, altogether 21 churches with a population of 3,294 members were under this Simte Christian Association. In 1959, the SCA was changed into New Testament Baptist Christian Association in the annual conference held at Dumsau Village. Later on, the name was further changed into New Testament Baptist Churches Association in 1972. It was registered on 20th February 1973 under Regd. No. 1192/SR/1973 of Societal Registration Act of 1860.^{xxi}

One significant contribution of the Baptist Mid-Mission and the Trinitarian Bible Society is worth mentioning here. The story of how the Simte Holy Bible came into existence. In an

interview with Deacon S.Thangchinkhai, 86 years, states that the Simte community always felt the need of translating the Bible into their own local dialect while they were under the Paite Presbytery. During those times, the Simte Christians were few in numbers as compared to the Paites. They appealed to the Bible Society of India (BSI) the need for Bible to evangelize the unreached and for discipling the new converts. But the BSI turned down their appeal due to her less population which will definitely have less Bible copies. He further added that the Paites reported to the BSI that they (Simte and Paite) spoke the same language. As such, no translation of Holy Bible in Simte was published during being in Presbytery with the Paites, broadly under the NEIGM^{xxii}.

The need for Simte Bible is still strong even after the institution of SCA. Even while negotiating for partnership with BMM, the first talk was about Bible translation. S. Paukhankhup in his article “*Khanglian*”, he asserted that James S.Garlow personally takes this matter very seriously and makes every effort for the production of Simte Bible. Apart from fundraising of the local churches for Bible fund, James S. Garlow initiated a fundraise from USA and other mission agencies. With the zeal and commitment of the BMM and NTBCA leaders such as H.Thangliankham, B.Nengzachin and L. Thangkhochin, the Simte New Testament was brought to Churachandpur in 1975. This first copy of the New Testament was published by the Trinitarian Bible Society (TBS), London. The dedication and thanksgiving programme for the new Simte Bible was held at Joutung killing mithuns, pigs and cows.^{xxiii} In line with this, the TBS Quarterly Record also states that the Simte Bible, comprising of New Testament and Psalms, project was started in 1965, and it was published in 1973. The dedication of the Simte Bible was held two years later i.e in 1975 at Joutung Village.^{xxiv} The Simte Holy Bible, comprising of both the OT and NT, reached Churachandpur on 24th November 1992. The dedication of the said Bible was held on 20th January, 1993 at NTBC, Lamka, followed by a pompous celebration at Tualbual (Thanlon) on 15th March, 1993.^{xxv} Interestingly, the TBS committed its love and affection towards the Simtes by taking up the Simte Bible reprinting work even today. God willing, as per sources received from a reliable person, the reprint copies of the Simte Holy Bible is expected to reach Churachandpur in the early months of 2022.

Conclusion:

The Simte Christian pioneers were persecuted by the village chiefs fearing that the new religion could destabilize their status quo. Besides this, the new found faith i.e. Christianity

was a threat to the old religious practice-Animism. Amidst the persecution and opposition, the tireless efforts of the evangelists and missionaries brought forth the Simtes into a community whose God is the LIVING GOD.

Footnotes:

ⁱ B. Chinlal, “Pathian Lemguatna limdang”, in B. Nengzachin, New Testament Baptist Churches Association Golden Jubilee Souvenir 1950-2000. Manipur:NTBCA Press, 2000,32-33

ⁱⁱ Rev. Th. Lamboi Vaiphei and Rev. Kh. Khaizakham, Gospel Centenary Souvenir: Commemorating the 100th Anniversary of Christianity in the Vaiphei community (Imphal: P. Vaiphei, February 2010), 83

ⁱⁱⁱ Rev. Th. Lamboi Vaiphei and Rev. Kh. Khaizakham, Gospel Centenary Souvenir: Commemorating the 100th Anniversary of Christianity in the Vaiphei community, 85-86

^{iv} B. Chinlal, “Pathian Lemguatna limdang”, in B. Nengzachin, New Testament Baptist Churches Association Golden Jubilee Souvenir 1950-2000,32

^v Khamkhosiam Hangnung, President, Baptist Partnership Ministry NTBCA (Churachandpur. Interview. 28 February 2018)

^{vi} S. Lianzathang Ngaihte, The Ngaihtes: Their history, religion, economy and settlement in the Chin hills of Myanmar and Manipur State in India (India: Ngaihte Innpi, 2016), 198

^{vii} S. Lianzathang Ngaihte, The Ngaihtes: Their history, religion, economy and settlement in the Chin hills of Myanmar and Manipur State in India, 199

^{viii} Ngaihte, The Ngaihtes, 195-196

^{ix} Ngaihte, The Ngaihtes, 199-200

^x Ngaihte, The Ngaihtes, 200-201

^{xi} Ngaihte, The Ngaihtes, 207

^{xii} L.Liankhanlal Simte, The Origin and Growth of Christianity among the Simtes in Manipur (B.D. Thesis, Eastern Theological College, 1997), 24-25

^{xiii} L.Liankhanlal Simte, The Origin and Growth of Christianity among the Simtes in Manipur, 25

^{xiv} Th. Kaikhochin, Deacon, NTBC Bible Hill (Churachandpur. Interview on 16th May 2018)

^{xv} L. Jeeyaselan, Impact of Missionary Movement in Manipur (New Delhi: Scholars’ Publishing House, 1996),117

^{xvi} Khamkhosiam Hangnung, President, Baptist Partnership Ministry NTBCA (Churachandpur. Interview. 28 February 2018)

^{xvii} Ts. Kaikhomang, L.Henzamang Thangsing Tanchinbu (Churachandpur: Ts. Kaikhomang and family, 2012), 10-11

^{xviii} Simte, The Origin and Growth of Christianity among the Simte in Manipur, 29

^{xix} Simte, The Origin and Growth of Christianity among the Simte in Manipur, 30

^{xx} Hh.Khaizathang, Deacon, NTBC Bible Hill (Churachandpur. Interview on 16th May 2018).

^{xxi} Simte, The Origin and Growth of Christianity among the Simte in Manipur, 30

^{xxii} S.Thangchinkhai , Deacon, NTBC (M) (Churachandpur: Interview on 24th April 2018). He is also the chairman of the GC, NTBCA in 1975, the year Simte NT and Psalms was inaugurated.

^{xxiii} S.Paukhankhup “Khanglian” in B. Nengzachin B. Nengzachin, New Testament Baptist Churches Association Golden Jubilee Souvenir 1950-2000. Manipur:NTBCA Press, 2000, 2

^{xxiv} P.J.D. Hopkins, “TBS Quarterly Record, Issue No. 617, October-December 2016, p. 13-14

^{xxv} Ginminthang Shoute, Telephonic Interview Project Co-ordinator cum Translator, Simte Bible Revision Committee, NTBCA (Mumbai:Telephonic Interview on 30th January, 2022)